

With the rise in incidents of kidnappings, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh raised the issue with Nigerian President Umaru Yar'Adua at the G-8 Summit held in Germany early this month. Diplomatic sources say Yar'Adua assured Singh that his Government will do its best to provide security to all the Indian workers.

The Indian High Commission in Nigeria has asked all Indians to take extra security precautions. It has also asked Indian companies to scale down their operations in the country, in order to bring the situation under control. "In view of the recent kidnappings and the high risk of further such

these kidnappings.

Despite the imminent danger, many Indian companies, particularly in the oil and the steel sector, still prefer to continue their operations because of the huge profits that they make there. Amongst the big Indian companies is the steel giant, Ispat Group. "The fact that the Prime Minister raised the issue with the Nigerian President has boosted our morale. But we are still living under fear and have been forced to take extra security precautions," says S.K.S. Warriar, GM, communications, Delta Steel, which is a part of the Ispat Group.

families are scared but are not ready to move out. While in most cases the companies have coughed up millions of dollars as ransom, with the sources estimating the total amount close to two million per person, fears have not subsided. "It is a difficult situation, although the Government of Nigeria has been sensitive to our concerns, and our bilateral ties still remain strong. Security situation has to improve for the Indian private sector so that they are comfortable investing in Nigeria," says Anil Trigunayat, India's deputy high commissioner to Nigeria.

For now, while the South Block is closely monitoring the develop-



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- 19 Indians have been kidnapped in the past three months, forcing many to flee the country.
- The Indian High Commission has asked Indian companies to scale down their operations.
- 35,000 Indians are living in Nigeria. The country supplies 20 per cent of oil to India.
- Militants in the Niger delta region are suspected to be behind the incidents. They want allocation of more resources for the poverty-struck region.

incidents, armed robberies and security related issues prevailing in the Niger delta, all Indian residents are advised to send their families and non-essential staff to safer locations. The businesses may also consider scaling down their operations in the region, to avoid any untoward incidents and unnecessary exposure to danger," says the advisory issued by the commission recently.

The rebel groups in Nigeria, like the Federated Niger Delta Ijaw Communities (FNDIC) feel that the core of the problem lies in the laxity of the Nigerian Government in addressing the political crisis prevailing in the Niger delta region. They argue that delta's 14 million ethnic Ijaws should have a bigger stake in the region's multibillion-dollar oil industry, which initially triggered

CRUNCH TIME: Manmohan Singh with Nigerian President Yar'Adua in Berlin

What has been worrying the governments on both the sides is that the intensity of the attacks has gone up. According to an assessment sent to the South Block, Indians have become a soft target and such incidents are going to rise in the future.

So far, 19 Indians have been kidnapped in the past four months alone. While in the latest incident in Port Harcourt, few Indians were abducted from their company's compound, in another, the militants wielding automatic rifles occupied an oil facility, holding several troops and 60 Nigerian oil workers as hostages.

Even though some Indians and their families have been evacuated to Lagos, more than 1,000 Indians are still living in the affected area. The

ments, more efforts need to be pooled in. India should seek the support of the Nigerian Government and the local administration, to ensure that diplomats are able to travel to the southern districts, in order to assess the condition of the Indian families.

The next step should be to engage other affected countries in the issue that have a stake in the region. It is intriguing that in the Foreign Office, not even a junior minister has been tasked to engage with the Nigerian Government to do a follow-up of the situation. Nevertheless, for India, crisis of these sorts, do not test its nerves to carry out a mammoth evacuation operation, but provide an opportunity for it to play the role of a leader beyond its immediate strategic neighbourhood, which for now it has failed to do. ■